

monotheism/一神论(Yī Shén Lùn)

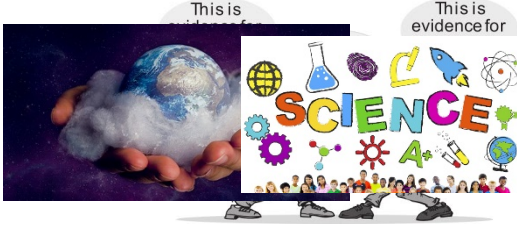
European
Perspective



Jan Assmann ~~RE Summer~~
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Creation and Science, conflicting or complimentary?

Key vocabulary	Explanation/ definition	Key Knowledge
Genesis	the first book of the Bible, which describes how God made the world	Pupils will know that: - There is much debate and some controversy around the relationship between the accounts in Genesis and contemporary scientific accounts. - These debates and controversies relate to the purpose and interpretation of the texts. e.g. does reading Genesis as a poetic account conflict with scientific accounts? - There are many scientists throughout history and now who are Christians. - The discoveries of science make Christians wonder even more about the power and majesty of the Creator. 
cosmology	the study of the nature and origin of the universe	
evolution	the way in which living things change and develop over millions of years	
universe	everything that exists, esp. all physical matter, including all the stars and planets in space	
contemporary	existing or happening now	
complementary	different but useful or attractive when used together	
conflict	if beliefs, needs, or facts, etc. conflict, they are very different and cannot easily exist together or both be true	
science	the systematic study of the structure and behaviour of the natural and physical	

	world, or knowledge obtained about the world by watching it carefully and experimenting.	
Key skills		
By the end of this unit, pupils are expected to be able to: - Outline the importance of Creation on the timeline of the 'Big Story' of the Bible. - Identify what type of text some Christians say Genesis 1 is, and its purpose. - Taking account of the context, suggest what Genesis might mean, and compare ideas with ways in which Christians interpret it, showing awareness of different interpretations. - Make clear connections between Genesis 1 and Christian belief about God as Creator. - Show understanding of why many Christians find science and faith go together. - Identify key ideas arising from their study of Genesis 1 and comment on how far these are helpful or inspiring, justifying their responses. - Weigh up how far the Genesis 1 creation narrative is in conflict, or is complementary, with a scientific account.		

The term "monotheism" first appeared in 1663 in Lord Herbert of Cherbury's book *De religione gentilium* (On the Religion of the Heathens). It refers to the concept of a primitive religion that was common to all humankind and worshipped nature as the only deity. According to Lord Herbert, the opposite, "polytheism", the worship of many different gods, developed only later among the peoples until, as a third stage, a new monotheistic religion was introduced in Israel, that was not based on nature but on revelation.

In the 20th century, the concept 'monotheism' developed in two different directions. On the one hand, it was now understood as the exclusive specificity of the "Abrahamic religions", i.e. Judaism, Christianity and Islam. On the other hand, a distinction was now made between an "exclusive" and an "inclusive" monotheism. One is based on the motto "No other gods!", the other on the motto "All gods are one". Forms of "inclusive monotheism" can be found all over the world, e.g. in the Egyptian, Neo-Babylonian, Hindu and Hellenistic (Stoic) religions. Only the "Abrahamic" religions know exclusive monotheism. In both traditions, God is praised as the "One and Only" - because other gods are forbidden, because there are no other gods, or because all gods merge into the One. Therefore, the concept of monotheism, which is based on the opposition of unity and multiplicity, is inadequate.

The decisive factor for exclusive monotheism is the connection between monotheism and covenant. This connection seems to exist only in the Hebrew Bible and the religions dependent on it. It appears there in two founding narratives. One refers to Abraham and the covenant between God and man, the other to Moses and the covenant between God and the people. Both are torn out of their accustomed living conditions, Abraham from Mesopotamia, Moses and the children of Israel from Egypt, and called into the covenant.

The central concept of this new religion is "faithfulness" or "faith", *emunah* in Hebrew, *pistis* in Greek, *fides* in Latin: faithfulness to the covenant and to the One with whom it was made, faith in the promise associated with this covenant: the "Promised Land", the "Paradise", the

27 "Redemption". The covenant between God and humanity founds the new religion of faith and
28 the new history that God and the people of faith have in common, the "history of salvation" that
29 runs towards the goal of redemption and in which all deeds have consequences. monotheism in
30 the Jewish, Christian or Islamic contexts thus means more than the conviction that there is only
31 one and not many gods. It means that this One God has revealed Himself to us in order to make
32 a covenant with us that demands from us faithfulness and trust.

33 The concept of faithfulness includes the existence of other gods with whom man or the people
34 could be unfaithful to God. So, this is not a strict monotheism that denies the existence of other
35 gods. However, this is also found in the Bible, namely where it is not about God as the liberator
36 from Egyptian bondage, but about the creator of heaven and earth, e.g. in the book of Genesis
37 and chapters 40ff. of the book of Isaiah. Here it is faith and faithfulness, that matter, but insight,
38 knowledge and wisdom. In the biblical monotheism both directions combine, faithfulness to
39 the One who saved us and shows the way to salvation, and knowledge of the One who created
40 heaven and earth and holds everything in his hands.

41 The covenant religion creates a counter-world in which God is king in opposition to the normal
42 world in which the princes of this world rule. Christianity has enormously sharpened this
43 difference between the "kingdom of God" and the "world" (*civitas divina* vs. *civitas terrena* in
44 Augustine). Between the invisible, extra-worldly God, who in an act of revelation establishes
45 in this world his covenant with a chosen group, and this world in which this group lives and
46 which is familiar to them, an abyss opens up which can only be bridged by faith. Therefore,
47 the new religion based on covenant and revelation combines with a system of rules that govern
48 life in the new world of the covenant.

49 This form of monotheism draws a line between before and after. People have lived before in a
50 world from which they must now move out in order to enter the new world of God's covenant.
51 Therefore, this religion is always "secondary" in the sense that it presupposes an older religion
52 which it must persecute and eradicate. The new takes the place of the old.

53 From the very beginning, the idea of revelation is connected with the medium of Scripture in
54 order to record forever God's revealed commandments and rules of life. In the course of time,
55 the most sacred texts are gathered into a canon and set apart as inviolable from the rest of
56 Scripture. In a changing world, however, commentary is needed in order to ensure the timeless
57 validity of the canonical texts. Thus, commentary works such as Mishnah and Talmud in
58 Judaism, the works of the Church Fathers in Christianity and the Hadith in Islam come into
59 being. Simultaneously with the canonisation of tradition, an orthodoxy develops in the
60 monotheistic religions that excludes deviating interpretations and teachings as heresy. This led
61 to persecutions of heretics, especially in Christianity and Islam. Within these religions, which
62 are based on Scripture and revelation, different directions and sects emerge, which at times, like
63 Catholicism and Protestantism in Christianity or Shia and Sunna in Islam, can lead to serious,
64 violent conflicts.

65 At the same time, the encounter with Greek, especially (Neo)Platonic philosophy resulted in a
66 proximity of monotheism and metaphysics. This proximity blurred the boundary to inclusive
67 monotheism, the distinction between the One Creator of heaven and earth and the One from
68 whom everything arose, the One who is everything, who does not confront the world as a creator
69 from outside, as subject and object, but incorporates it as an origin within himself. Examples of
70 this closeness are, for example, Lactanz, who relates the teachings of Hermes Trismegistus to
71 the God of Christian monotheism, Nikolaus von Kues, who more than 1000 years later
72 reinforces and extends the same lines, and Spinoza, who systematically dissolves the boundary
73 between God and the world and thus between monotheism and pantheism. This also includes
74 the doctrine of "prisca theologia", widespread in the 15th and 16th centuries, according to which

75 the true religion was already represented by Zoroaster and Hermes Trismegistus, who lived
76 long before Moses.

77 The three "Abrahamic" religions have rarely coexisted peacefully despite the commonality of
78 their origin. Christianity is not recognised as a pure monotheism by the other religions because
79 of its doctrine of the Sonship of Jesus Christ and its renunciation of the prohibition of images.
80 Islam criticises Judaism for the overly human emotionality of God in the biblical writings.
81 Christianity criticises Judaism for not recognising the Messiahship of Jesus Christ and Islam
82 for its fundamentalist understanding of the Scriptures. The problem of the three coexisting
83 monotheisms, which all refer to a revelation of their God given only to them, led to the literary
84 and factual institution of religious debates since the late 8th century, at which sometimes a
85 representative of "paganism" was invited in addition to those of the three monotheistic religions.
86 From this tradition also stem the ring parable known from Lessing's *Nathan the Wise*, in which
87 the three religions are compared to three rings that nobody can tell apart, and the pearl parable,
88 which compares the true religion to a pearl that someone throws into a house at night and which
89 only proves to be such, i.e. the true religion, at daybreak.

90 The term 'monotheism', thus, refers to religions that, apart from worshiping only one god,
91 distinguish strictly between God and world, creator and creation, and imply the idea of a
92 covenant of God and those who believe in him.

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